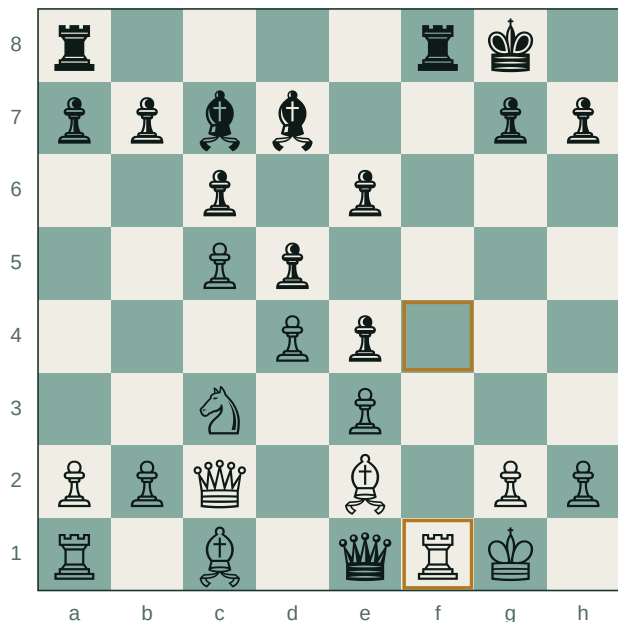


Clearance tactics: Black, move 16

Clearance tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 16.Rf1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16...Rxf1+ 17. Bxf1 Rf8 18. Qe2 Rxf1+ 19. Qxf1 Bxh2+ 20. Kxh2 Qxf1

16...Rxf1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the rook on f1. Recorded reply: **17.Bxf1**.

17...Rf8 The rook moves from a8 to f8. Recorded reply: **18.Qe2**.

18...Rxf1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the bishop on f1. Recorded reply: **19.Qxf1**.

19...Bxh2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on h2. Recorded reply: **20.Kxh2**.

20...Qxf1 The queen captures the queen on f1.

At the end, nominal material is White 17 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +5:** the balance goes from -2 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A clearance move vacates a square or opens a line for another piece. The clearing piece may sacrifice itself to gain the time needed for the follow-up.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on g1. Absolute pin: rook on f1.